SpeechGeek



Season Ten: Winter 2013

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Looking back, 2012 has been an action-packed year. *The Avengers* and *The Dark Knight* muscled their way into theaters and rescued lagging box office sales. Strength and agility also helped U.S. Olympians like Gabby Douglas bring home the gold. And chances are—if you're reading this—the Mayan calendar is being filed away with Y2K in the "Unnecessary End-of-the-Year Worries" box.

While everyone is trying to remember to write the right year, you've got plenty of other things keeping you busy. We're in the full swing of tournament season with district, state, and even national tournaments on the horizon. Your brain is chock full of memorized pieces, tournament planning to-do lists, and polishing pieces after reading ballots. The last thing you need to remember is to go out searching for new literature. That's why we went ahead and published five new pieces in addition to this letter. What a bargain!

Here's hoping that 2013 brings you good fortune, great ballots, and unforgettable performances!

Corey Alderdice
Publisher



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Content

by Wes Tantz

(*While smoking cigarette, Marion should be making subtle touches to her stomach because she is with child—but it shouldn't be obvious.)*

MARION. (*reading from book*) "Poets are always taking the weather so seriously. They are always sticking their emotions in things that have no feelings."

When I first started writing, I used to hail these gaudy beings as proof for why I was the way I was or why I did the things I did. After months of reading, re-reading, and a descent into nihilism, I just realized I was a woman who was too busy rotating on my axis to focus on the planets and shooting stars around me.

(*reading from book)* "All cowardice comes from not loving or not loving well."

Then again, maybe that's what it is. All of these people are too much on their axis, too. Or too busy sucking the life out of anything that remained nameless. You know, I never understood why love was such a holy topic. It's not all that, let me tell you. Let me tell you a story.

I knew a girl once who fell so in love with a boy. She fell and fell and fell and fell so far past the Earth that she spiraled out into the universe. She was carried by all these feelings that seemed warm and comforting, but once thrown into space, they were nothing. She floated with the dust and fell and fell and came to a black hole. There, she was sucked inside, and what did she find? Well, a party! There was booze, there was coke, there were people, and she danced until the stars shook and fell to her feet. There was John Lennon, Albert Einstein, and Ernest Hemingway. And you'll never believe who was hosting the party. Jesus H. Christ himself! Dressed in a pink suit, all Gatsby-like. So cool and so clique, waiting on his Daisy to float on by…(*laughs*). Hmm. You know that's why people never return from black holes. It's one endless party. I mean who'd want to? She sent me a postcard once. It was real nice. Jesus is a handsome looking fellow let me tell you. (*She laughs and continues to smoke.*)

Burned Out

by Julia Neva

MINIMALIST RUT – Julia Neva

6:30 a.m.
Hit snooze.
6:45 a.m.
Hit snooze.
7:00 a.m.
Stare up.
Consider options.
Hit snooze once more.
7:15 a.m.
Regret snooze.
Jump up.
Eat fast.
Shower faster.
Get dressed.
Run quick.
Sit down.
Stop talking.
Start writing.
Ask questions.
Get up.
Sit down.
Stop talking
Start writing.
Answer question.
Get corrected.
Get embarrassed.
Repeat.
Repeat.
Repeat.
Run home.
Get dressed.
Work out.
Run quick.
Run home.
Work more.
Call mom.
Call dad.
Eat fast.
Sleep now.

Repeat.
Hit snooze.
Hit snooze.
Jump up.
Run quick.
Sit down.
Get up.
Sit down.
Get up.
Ask questions.
Get corrected.
Run home.
Work out.
Run quick.
Work more.
Eat fast.
Sleep
Snooze
Jump
Run
Sit
Ask
Get
Run
Run
Work
Work
Work
Scream
Stop
Stop
Stop
Breathe
Call mom.
Call dad.
Sleep.
Hit snooze.
Stare up.
Consider options.
Stay home.
Write poems.
Count clouds.
Race pennies.
Mail cards.
Make s'mores.
Blow bubbles.

Eat slow.
Visit mom.
Hug dad.
Sleep.
Dream.

THE DANCER'S RESIGNATION LETTER – Julia Neva

If you're lucky,
the heart makes its quiet exit
before the rest of the body.
Unhinging the ribs, it opens
the cage, slinks over the
sternum the way a cowardly
lover separates from sheets —
It is quiet and unnoticed until gone.

If you're fortunate,
the mind checks out, leaves
before the rest gets to object.
Twisting the lock and key, it
shuts itself out and moves on
elsewhere, the way a drifter
learns to unlearn everything from before —
You are better off forgetting.

But if you're cursed,
the body burns out before
the heart and mind.
Once an orchestra of movement,
a symphony of vitality capable
of action and reaction becomes
brittle and inert. You become
meat and bone, no better
than bird or boar. That which
you love stands just beyond
your fingertips. Your life,
becomes an exercise
in reaching, never grasping.

I knew I could never love
a person the way I loved to dance.
No one could replicate the
weightlessness of rhythm.
I knew I could never trust
a person the way I trusted the cause

and effect of movement.
I devoted my life to dance as one
would a partner, a lover, a child.
I was never the best. But I
gave the best parts of myself.
I gave everything, and am
left with nothing.

So go on, now. Go.
Tell me more about your
waning interest, your
draining passion. How
the fireworks no longer
glitter and sizzle to your
satisfaction. Show me how
the matchstick of inspiration
has turned charred and used,
how you have burned out.

Please.
Tell me.
What is like
to still be able,
just uninterested?

THE GREAT EXODUS OF MT. PLEASANT HIGH SCHOOL – Julia Neva

It started with Ms. McKinney.
She taught senior English literature
for thirty-seven years, longer than all
of the P.E. teachers had been alive.

Some say it was the proximity of
retirement, that she could smell
the loaves of banana nut bread on
the horizon and decided to go cut a slice.

Others think it had something to do
with the lesson plan, that after
spending nearly four decades discussing
"The Yellow Wallpaper," she too had lost her mind.

A few people blame Marcus Wilson,
the notorious button-pusher,
for probably referring to it (again) as
Don Quicks-ottie and pushing her over the edge.

The only true thing we know is that on
February 17th, at 1:12 p.m. Ms. McKinney
walked out in the middle of class and
never set foot in the room again.

Her fourth period group sat in the empty
room for two thirds of the class time
before someone went to the main office.
They thought it was an exercise in symbolism.

The answer, like life, was far less glamorous
than the speculation. Stated plainly, simply,
in a letter to the administrators and parents,
"I am burned out and will not rise from the ash."

It soon became endemic. A plague of exhaustion
Spreading like flames through an over-worked
Though highly celebrated teaching staff. Math,
History, Economics, even bubbly Art teachers

No subject was safe from the burn out. The
Administration pretended it was about the
Money, parents pretended it was about the
Hours, students celebrated easier classes.

It would take ten years for us to realize what it
meant to burn out. The phrase we had so
carelessly tossed around when we were really
Tired, or bored, or in some cases, uninspired.

The empathy needed was light years beyond us.
We couldn't picture a young Ms. McKinney, her
face rounded and rouged, ready to inspire the
youth with print voices of a bygone time.

We had to learn what it meant to use your spirit
as collateral, to make your aspirations the reason
for waking in the morning, to push your patience
and yourself beyond its natural limits.

Like those that followed her weathered footprints,
Ms. McKinney had reached a point of no return.
She had poured out every drop of inspiration, joy,
and enthusiasm. Her well ran dry. She was empty.

Today, burning out is a rite of passage. Every song, every inspirational movie tells us to stand on desks, scream into the wind, extract every vibrating particle of life from the atmosphere that surrounds us.

We forget how exhausting it can be to live forty years believing every day was the last one. We forget how lonely it can be when no one ever stops to say, "No, I don't know what windmill they're talking about either."